

Studies Dedicated to the Memory

of

ROMAN JAKOBSON

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READING POETRY WITH ROMAN JAKOBSON

GRETE LÜBBE-GROTHUES

> Lass dich nicht verdriessen, den Dichter ... gleichsam zu zerstückeln; ich kenne nur diesen Weg, um aus der allgemeinen in die besondere Bewunderung zu gelangen.
>
> Goethe

I first came to know Roman Jakobson not as a theoretician of poetry, nor as an analyst of poems, but as a reader of verse. Puškin, Majakovskij, Mandel'štam, Esenin...: his memory yielded, inexhaustibly, whatever his wife or I suggested. I understood not a word of it, just as Krystyna Jakobson made out only rhythms and speech sounds when she listened to the Schiller or Hölderlin that I recited. We had dined in "Claudia" House; in the background, a fire blazed in the fireplace, while outside, the moon hung over the lake. Once, we spoke about those dimly unconscious perceptions of rhythm, through which a mere shift of the voice could give a prior judgment about possible understanding between people. Jakobson knew of a man who, on the basis of a voice heard on the telephone, sought out the woman to whom it belonged, found her, and never left her. My memory links this conversation to the heavenly evening the three of us spent together, when, through the medium of verses whose content played no role at all, a lasting sympathy was established.

This was in the early summer of 1974, following a presentation of Jakobson's in Zürich, to which I had driven from Einsiedeln. It isn't only specialists who bring along observations on the topic "child language", and I am surely not the only one who has followed the experiments and the striking linguistic discoveries in one's own children. The scientist of language explained the phases of child language acquisition - recount-

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ing phenomena which mothers know well, and with examples from many languages - in such a way that the rule-governed dynamics of language structuring and restructuring stood out prominently. We gained insight into a hierarchical system, and unusual linguistic anecdotes acquired significance as marks of particular or general elements in the evolution of language and its practice. Jakobson's interest in *invariants* did not lessen his attention to variation, but rather supported and even heightened it. This was an experience that later enabled me to fully understand his treatment of poetry.

After the presentation I was invited to join the guest's party, to keep company with Mrs.Jakobson, who did not speak German. The radiant Krystyna Pomorska, Professor of Slavic at MIT, did not feel at all timid at being the only woman among the learned men. Meanwhile, we took to one another easily; we discovered that we would be future neighbours on Sihlsee - and while I, being a confirmed Einsiedeln native, anticipated the pleasure of the coming Swiss summer, this chance meeting appeared to delight her as well. A few days later, the Jakobsons moved into "Sunnige Morge". Many get-togethers followed that evening in "Claudia", sometimes in STERNEN, halfway between our houses, where the Jakobsons often stopped for lunch; not to mention the excellent cooking, they struck up a friendship with Beo, a black bird who said "grüezi" ("howyadoin'") and "wihaischestu" ("watchername").

On one occasion, Krystyna came out to meet me from her house, and smilingly pointed out her husband, who, a few steps further, on the edge of the meadow (which at that time still extended as far as the lake), turned toward the garden table, sat down, and took some notes. "Look at Roman! All absorbed. That's how he is always working". She was certain that he didn't notice us. It was at that same red table that we had our first working conversation, late in the summer.

In languages which distinguish polite plurals in second-person address, Jakobson always chose the respectful form of address, even to children, who felt that he was always fully attentive to his addressee and the topic. When my twin girls returned from a visit at Krystyna's (with whom they had a lot of fun massacring German and English), they were filled with enthusiasm by the way Jakobson had spoken to the 12-year-olds about their upcoming selection of Greek or English; this conversation instilled in them an extraordinary enthusiasm. Krystyna, almost surprised that I had emphasized it, said, "Of course!! *All* girls love him".

Before the magnificent cloister church that towers over Einsiedeln, many a person automatically experiences a sensation that goes beyond the aesthetic. Thus a well-known German philosopher reacted with astonishment at the "stubborn obscurantism" that became manifest to him in the lighting of candles before carved and painted images. Such conventional acts were probably alien to a man like Jakobson, who knew the discoveries and puzzles of science; but the unabashed agnosticism of such judgments was surely also alien to him. A remark on his Polish wife's sympathy for the Black Madonna revealed not only tolerance, but a respectful understanding of the very depth of one's native religion.

Scholars and artists speaking various languages came to Einsiedeln to spend their vacations and to work; in spite of Jakobson's fixed working schedule, a relaxed social life thrived around him. Naturally, the one feeds on the other. Most of the people with whom Jakobson associated here were easily a generation younger, but this was forgotten in conversation. He certainly was the center of attention, but he was never domineering, all the less so since he was a good listener. I noticed just how carefully he had followed, for example, a theological conversation of his table-companions when he pursued the topic on the way home. He spoke his native language with his wife, otherwise he preferred to use the native language of his interlocutor. The three of us used English together, but about Hölderlin he always spoke to me in German.

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Jakobson had given his wife an anthology of German poetry, with English translations, which happened to contain Hölderlin's last poem. When I returned, after being away for several weeks, he said right away, with an infectious excitement: "We must talk about this".

On the first Sunday in September I met him outdoors. "Let's get started!" I took out my notes, and explained what had struck me about the eight-line poem: its sense of measure (the alternating verse-lengths, the succession of couplets, the parallel sentence-structures of the stanzas, correspondences in sounds and words). I had found all of the seasons of the year referred to. I had worried over the possible meanings of the title "Die Aussicht" ["The View"] (on the vineyard? on death? on his entire life?), and I went as far as a broad interpretation of the apparent relation between nature and history.

Jakobson left my premature discoveries aside and

commenced an examination of the details, as if through a magnifying glass, which brought into prominence previously imperceptible distinctions. He showed not only that the two stanzas (and the couplets within them) subdivided the poem horizontally into equivalent units, but also that a consistent word-boundary before every seventh-to-last syllable constituted the poem's caesura. Within the crossthreads of these horizontal and vertical axes, he then examined the linguistic elements of the poem's surface, as if they were colors and shapes in a carpet. His notes (for example, observations on word-distribution) had been jotted down in a heap of small slips of paper which were later organized in a folding card-file. Whether he set his sights on nouns or verbs, or whether he was analyzing case, number, or gender, or had distinguished between words of the same category in terms of sound, accent, and form, it was utterly fascinating - symmetries always emerged, patterns always appeared.

It was in this game of pattern-hunting that I began to discover parallel structures. At each meeting we added something new to our last session. Finally, I typed out the poem's metrical scheme, and with colored pencils I recorded on this framework, using *X*'s, the deviations in rhythm, the word-boundaries, syntactic parallelisms, parallelisms in sounds and words, designations of time and place, synonyms and antonyms ... In this abstract schema, the symmetries, in their various forms, became manifest. At a farewell party in STERNEN with his closest friends of this time (the proprietor, at the end, gave us a *crème russe* on the house), Jakobson glanced over the typed sheets, tucked them away, and gave me a nod. The next morning he was waiting even before the agreed time; Krystyna had gone on ahead with other friends. It was on this trip to Zürich that he formally invited me to collaborate with him.

Through this "game" of uncovering symmetries, one can trace the rules of the game of conscious and unconscious poetic structure. In his theory of the poetic function (which first became evident to me in the actual practice of analysis), Jakobson has formulated an invariant of poetic organization. Let me try to explain this linguistic formulation: what makes a poem a poem is the dominance of the poetic function over the other functions of language (to inform, to express, to impose one's will, to keep contact, to communicate about the means of communication). Where the poetic predominates, the text is organized primarily according to the principle of equivalence. Everyone can see

this easily in all forms of rhyme (sound equivalences), refrain (syntactic equivalences), and rhythm (metrical equivalences); but it was Jakobson who first demonstrated the extent to which this applies to grammatical categories as well. Jakobson had to fight for his linguistic poetics on two fronts. Linguists missed the systematic completeness of his analyses of particular poems, and chalked up his metaphorical expressions as a "relapse" into "the subjective style". Specialists in literature found the subtle grammatical distinctions "impossible to follow", and would rather have found out more directly "what the poem says". One of them even asked what these symmetries being pointed out had to do with our enjoyment of poetry. Jakobson answered him, with Baudelaire (who was well aware of the "architecture of the word" and the "plasticity" of language in poetry), that on the one hand, arrangement and proportion are fundamental requirements of the human disposition, while on the other hand the unexpected and the surprising are essential ingredients of all artistic enjoyment. As shown in his "Retrospect" (*Selected Writings* III, 1981), Jakobson could be a polemicist ("Des coups d'épée, Messieurs...!"), and perhaps also a tactician (during a conference, I heard a younger colleague whispering, with respect, about the "old fox"). If it was compatible with a spirit of enjoyment in the game, he himself never shrank from "coups d'épingle": his "horrible Harry" (a test for the unconscious preference for sound similarity in poetry which was used to try out a series of insulting adjectives applied to one and the same name) referred in a hidden way to one of his adversaries.

In August of 1975, the Jakobsons moved into "Aurora" House, the twin of "Claudia" House. In the meantime, with the labour partly divided, we had broadened the scope of our investigation; we were both occupied with the poems and documents of the time of Hölderlin's illness. Jakobson freely and easily wrote out the first draft, and it was my job to put it into "good German" and to type it. In the months that followed we exchanged the text by mail. Jakobson wrote: "I am fascinated more and more by our 'Aussicht', which reveals still new and new secrets". The study appeared at the end of 1976 (together with the earlier analyses of poems by Klee and Brecht) in Suhrkamp's "pocket book" series (vol.162). In the spring of 1976 we worked for one more week, at the same writing desk, in the spacious study of Jakobson's home in Cambridge.

As I look back from this distance, I recall a brief period of inner rebellion, when I struggled with the

idea that my own work would have meaning only as a prop for the intentions of this gifted scholar. From personal experience, I fully understand the impatience which the eager reader or critic brings into the insights which Jakobson's reading of poetry can produce. For some time, I myself leaned prematurely toward the perspective of meaning: what did the poem's depth of inner depression have to do with prefixes and suffixes (which turned up in patterns that we described!), or what did distinctions among even the smallest units of sound have to do with the meaning of this poem? Later I came to understand just how much I owed to such a strict microscopic exercise "divorced" from considerations of meaning.

Jakobson, like Goethe, is preeminent as a scientist: the "data should be set down and organized in series - not assembled according to any one hypothesis, and not applied to any systematic mold. Only then is each person free to link them in his own way and to construct from this a totality".

Jakobson was cautious with interpretations which in fact represented the interpreter's intuition. But there is already more of interest in the grammatical data Jakobson organized and in the contextual and documentary factors he considered than in what critics of Hölderlin's late poetry have observed until now.

I once expressly thanked Jakobson for having called into question my premature interpretations (a "kairos"-poem, a universal affirmation, harmony) by means of his skeptical silence. Much later, I attempted "in my own way" (and at my own risk) to view the phenomenon of the Scardanelli-poetry as a "totality" (*Philos. Jahrbuch* 1983). Like most other interpretations, it is open to criticism, correction, and revision. But Jakobson's "data" are relied upon not only by literary criticism, but affect other areas of the humanities as well.

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Roman Jakobson's last book, written together with Krystyna Pomorska, is entitled *Dialogues* (1983); it is a summation of his research, prepared in the form of exchanges with the woman who was his daily interlocutor for the last third of his life. She was able to survey, as few others could have, his enormous output, and her admiration for this brilliant man seemed to show itself in every respect. When, at 84, he was the victim of a sudden and serious eye disorder, she wrote to me with the expectation that he would regain his eyesight completely: "I firmly believe in it; he is such a giant". Her belief became reality. Two years

later, in the beginning of 1982, he wrote me: "My chief preoccupation for all these months has been various proof readings. But now I hope to go over to more creative activities".

By June, he could no longer come to Stuttgart to receive the Hegel Prize. He expressed his thanks in a brief text: with great simplicity, he structurally aligned his linguistic theory with Hegelian thought, and, basing himself on the thesis of the "inseparability of invariance and variability", he formulated at the same time the necessary conditions for the scientific analysis of living systems (*NZZ* Nr.221, 1982). The "Russian philologist" (his own self-designation) died in Boston on July 18th. A few weeks later, Krystyna Pomorska delivered his last lecture at the International Congress of Armenian Linguistics in Erevan, Armenia.

My last recollection: the three of us again, in the Vier Jahreszeiten bar in Munich, after the fourth Werner Heisenberg lecture in 1978. Jakobson had tied the results of the most recent neurophysiological research, especially in Russia, to linguistic findings, producing interdisciplinary evidence through the mutual illumination of both perspectives. My astonishment showed him that it wasn't only specialists he had impressed with the complex material. In the din of music and voices, communicative discourse was impossible, but this time with no ill effects on our well-being. Jakobson sat there smiling and relaxed, and Krystyna toasted him: "You were excellent, Roman. I do not always tell you so, but you were great!"

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Translated from German
by BRENT VINE